

Physician smoking status, attitudes toward smoking, and cessation advice to patients: an international survey.

OBJECTIVE: The smoking status of physicians can impact interactions with patients about smoking. The 'Smoking: The Opinions of Physicians' (STOP) survey examined whether an association existed between physician smoking status and beliefs about smoking and cessation and a physician's clinical interactions with patients relevant to smoking cessation, and perceptions of barriers to assisting with quitting. **METHODS:** General and family practitioners across 16 countries were surveyed via telephone or face-to-face interviews using a convenience-sample methodology. Physician smoking status was self-reported. **RESULTS:** Of 4473 physicians invited, 2836 (63%) participated in the survey, 1200 (42%) of whom were smokers. Significantly fewer smoking than non-smoking physicians volunteered that smoking was a harmful activity (64% vs 77%; $P<0.001$). More non-smokers agreed that smoking cessation was the single biggest step to improving health (88% vs 82%; $P<0.001$) and discussed smoking at every visit (45% vs 34%; $P<0.001$). Although more non-smoking physicians identified willpower (37% vs 32%; $P<0.001$) and lack of interest (28% vs 22%; $P<0.001$) as barriers to quitting, more smoking physicians saw stress as a barrier (16% vs 10%; $P<0.001$). **CONCLUSION:** Smoking physicians are less likely to initiate cessation interventions. **PRACTICE IMPLICATIONS:** There is a need for specific strategies to encourage smoking physicians to quit, and to motivate all practitioners to adopt systematic approaches to assisting with smoking cessation.